

Two Visitors

Two winters had passed. Heidi was excited because spring was near. This meant warm, gentle winds and the opportunity to play outdoors. She looked forward to seeing the beautiful flowers covering the pastures. She had become skilled in taking care of the goats. They followed her around everywhere.

Heidi was almost eight years old now, and the village school teacher wanted her to start school. But her grandfather had delayed it. He kept her with him instead.

One bright morning in March, as Heidi played outside, a man dressed in black approached her. Seeing her startled look, he kindly reassured her. He said he loved children and asked her not to be afraid. He wanted to know where her grandfather was. Heidi said he was inside, crafting wooden spoons. She led the man inside.

The visitor was the old village parson. He was a long-time friend of Grandfather. When he saw the parson, Grandfather greeted him warmly. He offered him a place to sit. Taking a seat, the parson said: "It's been a long time, neighbor. I have come today to talk with you about something. I'm

sure you can guess what it is."

Grandfather glanced at Heidi standing nearby. "Heidi, run out to see to the goats," said Grandfather. "And bring them some salt. You can stay until I come get you." Heidi swiftly went out as her grandfather had asked.

With Heidi gone, the parson brought up the topic of school. He said Heidi should have already started the previous year.

"I don't want her to go to school," said the old man.

"What do you want the child to do then?"

"I want her to be free and happy as a bird!"

"But she's not a bird, she's a little girl. It's high time for her to learn something. I've come to tell you that so you can make your plans. She needs to come to school next winter."

"I won't do it!" Grandfather shouted. "What about when there's a storm or it's freezing out? It's a two-hour walk! I won't let her go. The wind even chokes me if I go out in the wrong weather. Did you know Adelheid, her mother? She was very delicate, and would even faint sometimes. What if that happens to Heidi? Nobody can make me let her go. I'll fight it in court!"

"You're right," the parson said kindly. "You shouldn't send her to school from here. Why don't you come down to live in the village again? You're leading a strange life here. How can you even keep the child warm in winter?"

"She's young and strong. I keep a fire going all winter. And I couldn't live in the village. The people there hate me, and I hate them."





The parson visits with Grandfather

“You’re wrong about that, I’m sure! Make your peace with God, and then you’ll see how happy you will be.” The parson stood and held out his hand. “I’ll look for you and Heidi next winter, neighbor. We’ll be happy to see you.”

Grandfather shook his visitor’s hand and said, “Thank you for your kindness, but that will never happen.”

“God be with you,” said the parson, and left him sadly.

The old man was feeling grumpy the rest of that day. When Heidi asked him if she could visit Grandmother, he just said, “Not today.”

The next day, they had just finished eating lunch when someone else came to visit. It was Heidi’s aunt Deta. She looked very fancy. She wore a long dress that cleaned the floor as she walked. Grandfather just stared at her silently. Deta started to thank him and say how healthy Heidi looked. She apologized for leaving her with him for so long. She said that she had found a great opportunity for Heidi in Frankfurt. There was a rich family who needed a friend for their daughter. The daughter couldn’t walk and used a wheelchair. This girl needed someone to play and learn with her. Deta thought Heidi was perfect for the job.

Grandfather seemed uninterested in Deta’s proposal and was ignoring her. Deta got angry and said anyone else would be thankful for such news. She said Heidi was eight and didn’t know anything because the old man hadn’t sent her to school or church. Deta felt it was her job to look after Heidi. She felt strongly that this was a chance of a lifetime. She warned Grandfather to be very careful what he did next.

“Be quiet!” Grandfather thundered with flaming eyes. “Take her and ruin her, but don’t bring her back! I do not want to see her looking all fancy and speaking wicked words the way you do.” With that, he stormed out of the hut.

Heidi looked upset and said, “You made him mad!”

“He won’t stay mad long. Now, where are your things?” Deta asked.

“I’m not going,” Heidi said firmly.

Deta looked surprised. “What?” Then more gently she added, “Listen, I’m taking you to a wonderful place. The most beautiful you’ve ever seen.” As she packed Heidi’s clothes, she said again, “Come on, get your hat. It’s not the best hat, but it’s what we have.”

Heidi still said, “I won’t go.”

“Don’t be stubborn like a goat,” Deta responded. “We have to go like Grandfather said. If we don’t, he’ll be even more upset. You’ll love Frankfurt. If you don’t, we can come back. How does that sound?”

Heidi asked, “Can we come back tonight?”

“Not tonight,” Deta explained, “But soon. We’ll take a train and it’ll be fast.” Deta held Heidi’s bag, and they started walking down the mountain.

They met Peter. He had skipped school to gather sticks, which he felt was more useful. He had a big bundle of them. Seeing Heidi and Deta, he asked, “Where are you going?”

Heidi said, “To Frankfurt with Aunt Deta. But I must see Grandmother first. She’s probably waiting for me.”

“It’s too late now,” Deta said quickly, pulling Heidi. She

worried Grandmother might make them stay.

Peter ran to tell Grandmother. He went into her house and slammed his bundle down. Grandmother got scared and asked what was happening. Peter said sadly, “They’ve taken Heidi away.”

“She’s gone?” the worried old woman asked. Brigida had seen Deta walking up the path a little while before. The two soon guessed what had happened. The old woman was shaking. She opened a window and called out as loudly as she could, “Deta! Deta, please don’t take the child away! Don’t take her from us!”

When Heidi heard this, she tried to break free, saying, “I have to go to Grandmother. She’s calling me.”

But Deta wouldn’t let her go. She hurried Heidi along by promising she could come back soon. She said Heidi could even bring a nice gift for Grandmother when she returned.

Heidi liked the idea of bringing a gift and followed Deta without arguing. After a bit, Heidi asked, “What should I bring to Grandmother?”

“You could bring her some soft white rolls, Heidi. The black bread is too hard for poor Grandmother to eat.”

“Yes, I know. She always gives it to Peter,” Heidi agreed. “We have to hurry now. If we get to Frankfurt today, I can come back tomorrow with the rolls.”

Heidi started to run, and Deta struggled to keep up. Deta avoided the villagers’ questions about why Heidi was leaving. As they saw Heidi pulling Deta along, she said, “I can’t stop. Can’t you see the child is in a hurry? We still have a long way



*Dete runs after Heidi*

to go.”

The villagers whispered among themselves. They wondered if Heidi was going with Dete willingly. Or maybe she was running away from her grandfather. They were surprised to see her looking so healthy and rosy. But soon, Heidi and Dete were far from the village.

From then on, Grandfather looked angrier whenever he came down to the village. He was only there to sell his goat cheese and buy food. People were scared of him and told their children to stay away. Many people thought it was good that Heidi had left him. They had seen her rushing away and thought she was happy to go.

Only Grandmother still supported him faithfully. Whenever someone came near her, she would talk about how well the old man had taken care of Heidi. She would also tell them how he had fixed up her little house. People in the village only half believed these stories because Grandmother was very old and frail. She started feeling sad again every day. “All the happiness left when Heidi did,” the old woman would say every day. “The days are so long and dull, and I don’t feel happy anymore. I wish I could hear Heidi’s voice one more time before I pass away.”